If you are using `select` (or similar helpers such as `collection_select`, `select_tag`) to set a `belongs_to` association you must pass the name of the foreign key (in the example above `city_id`), not the name of association itself. If you specify `city` instead of `city_id`Active Record will raise an error along the lines of `ActiveRecord::AssociationTypeMismatch: City(#17815740) expected, got String(#1138750)` when you pass the `params` hash to `Person.new` or `update`. Another way of looking at this is that form helpers only edit attributes. You should also be aware of the potential security ramifications of allowing users to edit foreign keys directly.

## 3.3 Option Tags from a Collection of Arbitrary Objects

Generating options tags with `options_for_select` requires that you create an array containing the text and value for each option. But what if you had a `City` model (perhaps an Active Record one) and you wanted to generate option tags from a collection of those objects? One solution would be to make a nested array by iterating over them:

```
<% cities_array = City.all.map { |city| [city.name, city.id] } %>
<%= options_for_select(cities_array) %>
```

This is a perfectly valid solution, but Rails provides a less verbose alternative: `options_from_collection_for_select`. This helper expects a collection of arbitrary objects and two additional arguments: the names of the methods to read the option **value** and **text** from, respectively:

```
<%= options_from_collection_for_select(City.all, :id, :name) %>
```

As the name implies, this only generates option tags. To generate a working select box you would need to use it in conjunction with `select_tag`, just as you would with `options_for_select`. When working with model objects, just as `select` combines `select_tag` and `options_for_select`, `collection_select` combines `select_tag` with `options_from_collection_for_select`.

```
<%= collection_select(:person, :city_id, City.all, :id, :name) %>
```

As with other helpers, if you were to use the `collection_select` helper on a form builder scoped to the `@person` object, the syntax would be:

```
<%= f.collection_select(:city_id, City.all, :id, :name) %>
```

To recap, `options_from_collection_for_select` is to `collection_select` what `options_for_select` is to `select`.

Pairs passed to `options_for_select` should have the name first and the id second, however with `options_from_collection_for_select` the first argument is the value method and the second the text method.

## 3.4 Time Zone and Country Select

To leverage time zone support in Rails, you have to ask your users what time zone they are in. Doing so would require generating select options from a list of pre-defined TimeZone objects using `collection_select`, but you can simply use the `time_zone_select` helper that already wraps this:

```
<%= time_zone_select(:person, :time_zone) %>
```

There is also `time_zone_options_for_select` helper for a more manual (therefore more customizable) way of doing this. Read the API documentation to learn about the possible arguments for these two methods.

Rails *used* to have a `country_select` helper for choosing countries, but this has been extracted to the country_select plugin. When using this, be aware that the exclusion or inclusion of certain names from the list can be somewhat controversial (and was the reason this functionality was extracted from Rails).